

Tobias Treppmann

Design leader who still builds — UX maturity raised three times, AI shipped into production

CONTACT

LOCATION

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EDUCATION

M.A. Leadership

Kairos University, South Dakota, USA

2022 – 2026

Theological Studies

Theologisches Seminar Rheinland

2003 – 2007

LANGUAGES

German · native

English · C2, fluent

ONGOING

Independent Consultant

Oratio&Co

2016 – Present · Remote

Collaborative leadership coaching and product-strategy consulting for mission-driven organisations.

PROFILE

I lead design functions and I still build. The last year went into AI that runs in production — a support copilot, a fundraising system I built end to end, and prototypes engineering ships from. Before that, fifteen years raising UX maturity at Ninox, Datameer and Spreadshirt.

EXPERIENCE

Head of Product Design

2025 – Present

Bibel TV (broadcaster in linear-to-streaming transformation — iOS, Android, web, connected TV; engineering is an external agency) · Hamburg + Berlin, Germany

- AI support copilot, live in production — assistive drafting for viewer letters, emails and social messages, following the handbook's wording, formatting and standard phrases. Restricted topics are enforced in the output. Crisis messages escalate to a person rather than being drafted, and every send decision stays human. Rolled out fully optional. Trust was the design problem, not a property added afterwards.
- AI fundraising ecosystem, built solo end to end — analysis, prompt architecture, prototype, then a production Claude skill generating follow-up content across in-app, web and video.
- Agentic engineering as a design practice — prototypes run on real APIs and the agency ships from that code. Around 70% of AI-generated code lands. Iteration went from days to hours, and the handoff crosses a company boundary.
- AI in the research loop — interviews transcribed in Teams, then analysed with Claude. Above a few hundred data points that analysis happens or it does not happen at all; below it, I read the responses.
- Product strategy for the platform — competitive analysis against global entrants to the German market, and a differentiation strategy built on local content. Leading the redesign across iOS, Android and web for engagement and retention.
- Design system as an API, and the tooling on top of it — DTCG tokens and multi-platform sync, built without a platform team. A colour-extraction API and config tool drive image-based gradients that hold WCAG contrast in both modes. Building an MCP server so designers can prototype with the system's cross-platform web components. No direct reports here — function leadership and practice change rather than headcount.

Head of Platform and Design

2024 – 2025

ChurchDesk (vertical ERP for churches and dioceses — ~50 people, DE / DK / UK / SE / NO / CH) · Copenhagen, Denmark · Remote from Berlin

- Product management and design at once — owned the main platform as PM alongside all product design. Wrote the specs, ran the ticket board engineering worked from, and was the main customer-facing contact throughout.
- The decision I defended through the build — reframed a client request into a platform capability and took €20k of client funding on that condition, choosing deep integration over the faster standalone module. 70% coordination-time reduction and 90% acceptance at the launch customer, where funerals had to be bookable across 20+ cemeteries. It then shipped to every customer as a general booking capability, for room rentals and weddings as much as funerals.
- AI alt-text in production — shipped for EU accessibility compliance under GDPR plus Protestant and Catholic church data-protection law, across six countries.
- 1 direct report (designer), and the bar was mine to set with no design organisation above me.

Head of Product Design

2023 – 2024

Ninox Software GmbH (no-code business platform — DACH / UK / US; the company was growing) · Berlin, Germany

- Senior Leadership Team, 5 direct reports including a design lead — established design as a function co-equal with product and engineering, and advanced UX maturity through a collaborative self-assessment rather than an imposed model.
- The full range of people decisions — hired two, promoted two, let two go. Coached the design lead through a difficult cross-functional relationship.
- Interim Head of Product, July to October 2023 — then hired the consultant who was subsequently brought in as Head of Product. Covering the role and recruiting the person who took it are two different pieces of evidence, and the second is the one I would point at.
- Redesigned how the team ran meetings — pre-meeting prep, written agendas, structured turn-taking, decisions written down. An engineer who had been talked over became one of the strongest contributors, and the habits outlived the problem. Inclusion as a design problem, not a value statement.
- Prompt-to-database onboarding, with the CEO and technical co-founder (freelance, summer 2025) — the AI-generated schema renders into the real data-model editor, not a chat preview. It became the basis for the public AI beta.

Product & UX Strategist

2021 – 2022

Hypoport hub SE (shared services arm of listed Hypoport SE — 100+ people) · Berlin / Lübeck, Germany · Remote

- Service-to-product transformation — partnered with the executive team to productise the service organisation. Case-by-case support became a standard catalogue.
- Methodology transfer — ran design-thinking training for executive leadership and service teams, as the primary stakeholder contact for the programme.

Director of Design

2016 – 2021

Datameer GmbH (collaborative data analytics for top US / CA / UK banks and insurers) · Berlin, Germany · team across Germany and NYC

- Led the design team across Germany and NYC for five years — two UX designers reporting to me inside a four-person design org, reporting to the VP Design. A six-hour gap, held together by cross-timezone collaboration processes I established.
- UX maturity, measurably increased — moved design from an execution function to a strategic partner and secured executive support for user research.
- Research inside institutions that make users hard to reach — pioneered iterative usertesting.com screening to get to analysts working inside banks and insurers. The platform operated under HIPAA compliance among other frameworks.
- Data-dense interfaces — big-data pivot tables, column charts, aggregated JSON views and filter logic. The hardest was the query-builder preview, where the result you see is a sample and the interface has to be honest about that without becoming unreadable.

EARLIER CAREER PROGRESSION

UX Strategy Lead · *Spreadshirt* · 2014 – 2016 · Leipzig, Germany
UX Manager · *HairDirect* · 2013 – 2014 · Lancaster, PA, USA
User Experience Designer · *andCulture* · 2012 – 2013 · Harrisburg, PA, USA
Web Designer & Front-End Developer · *HOPE International* · 2009 – 2012 · Lancaster, PA, USA
Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2008 – 2009 · Düsseldorf, Germany
Freelance Web Designer · 2003 – 2008 · Düsseldorf, Germany
Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2000 – 2003 · Düsseldorf, Germany
E-Commerce Assistant · *Westfalia Werkzeugcompany* · 1999 · Hagen, Germany

SKILLS

UX Maturity and Function Leadership

Three maturity advances, each with a named method: collaborative self-assessment at Ninox, a measured increase at Datameer with executive support secured for research, a scaled assessment framework across a 200+ matrix organisation at Spreadshirt · Design established as co-equal with product and engineering · UX standards and shared design-system governance

People and Performance

Senior Leadership Team member · 5 direct reports including a design lead · Hired two, promoted two, let two go · Coaching a design lead through cross-functional conflict · Team norms redesigned so the quietest contributor became one of the strongest · Hired a Head of Product into a role I was covering

Product Strategy and Executive Partnership

Product management of a platform alongside its design · Interim Head of Product · Roadmap ownership · Executive partnership on a service-to-product transformation · A product-strategy assumption reversed with user research · C-level presentation across four employers

Research Practice

Iterative usertesting.com screening for personas inside regulated institutions · Research protocols and executive sponsorship secured · Dovetail as a shared insight repository · Claude over thousands of forum posts, and Teams transcription into Claude for interviews · The threshold — AI analysis above a few hundred data points, direct reading below

AI in Production

Customer-support copilot live in production · AI fundraising ecosystem built solo end to end · Human-in-the-loop by design: escalation as a first-class output, the send decision stays human · Agentic engineering with Claude Code on real APIs · Design system as an API · DTCG tokens · Style Dictionary

Enterprise, Regulated and Multi-Market

Vertical ERP across six countries · No-code business platform across DACH / UK / US · Top US / CA / UK banks and insurers · HIPAA-compliant analytics platform · GDPR plus church data-protection law · EU accessibility compliance shipped · German native, English C2